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MISSION ■ BUILT

V2.0 · SECOND EDITION

■ THE FIELD GUIDE

MISSION BUILT.

— A FIELD GUIDE FOR BUILDING
THINGS THAT MATTER.

BY

MIKE NICHOLS

EDITION

SECOND · 2026

■■■ SECOND EDITION • 2026 ■■■

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A FIELD GUIDE FOR BUILDING
THINGS THAT MATTER.

MIKE NICHOLS

Mission Built: A Field Guide for Building Things That Matter

by Mike Nichols

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A NOTE ON THE SECOND EDITION

If you read the first edition of *Mission Built*, welcome back. A few things changed.

Most visibly, the second edition adds a chapter. Chapter 13 — *AI Is the New OS. The Mission Is the Only App That Matters.* — exists because 2026 forced the question. AI raised the floor of average work in a way no tool ever has. The book's central argument — that mission, reps, feedback, recovery, and ownership are what produce real strength — needed to be tested against the loudest tool of the year. So I tested it. Twice. Once under the bar, once in the boardroom.

A few other additions you'll notice. The Drift, named once in the first edition, now recurs as a deliberate framework — Boeing's Drift in Chapter 1, recovery-shaped Drift in Chapter 6, legacy-shaped Drift in Chapter 12, and the AI-shaped Drift in Chapter 13. Three appearances of an idea is when it becomes a reader's framework. Four is when it becomes the spine of how you think about work.

The give-a-shit motto now has its source on the page. Marine squadron VMM-364, the Purple Foxes. CASEVAC pilots flying into enemy fire to bring wounded troops home. Three words on their patch. The motto came to me through Nate Fick at Endgame, and it has been the working motto of my career.

Some examples are paired with 2024–2026 updates. Boeing's 737 MAX with the 2024 Alaska Airlines door plug. Cyberpunk 2077 with the Humane AI Pin. The principle holds. The evidence is current.

The book is shorter than the first edition by about ten pages, despite the new chapter. The prose was tightened. Less padding, more spine.

What didn't change: the voice, the mission, the give-a-shit. Those are the work.

— Mike

WHO I WROTE THIS FOR

This book is for anyone who builds things.

GMs and PMs trying to figure out what matters most. Engineers who want to know why the work is what it is. Designers who care more about the user than the demo. Leaders trying to lead instead of manage.

If you spend your days deciding what to ship and how, this book is for you. It is not a methodology. It is not a framework you have to adopt. It is a field guide for the why beneath the what. For the principles that hold when the deadline shifts, the strategy changes, the tooling evolves, and the team turns over.

I am also a powerlifter and a coach. I have spent more than a decade under the bar. I lean on that world throughout this book, but not because I expect you to lift. The gym is one of the cleanest mirrors I know for the work we actually do in product. Honest input. Reps that matter. Systems tested under load. The bar is just the example. The principle is the point.

It's also a leadership book, in the way the best leadership books are: a collection of specific stories about what actually mattered when the work got hard. Endgame. Elastic Security. The military. The barbell. The CAOC at Nellis. Lived examples, not borrowed wisdom.

Most of all, this is a book about empathy.

That word has gotten lighter than it should be. We live in a time when caring for others gets called weak. When standing up for someone besides yourself gets called foolish. When the loudest voices argue that strength is what you take and softness is what you give away.

I disagree. I have spent my whole career proving the opposite. In uniform. Defending networks. Building products. Coaching lifters. The same lesson, every time. Real strength is what you give. The mission lives in the people next to you. The user is on the other end of every decision. Empathy isn't softness. It's clarity. It's what makes the work worth doing in the first place.

If that resonates with you, this book is for you.

BUILT FOR MORE

July 2016. The Combined Air Operations Center at Nellis Air Force Base. Red Flag is about to begin. My engineering lead and I are standing silent on the floor. Our agent is deployed on systems across the room. Pilots are about to be in the air. Controllers will guide them. Air defense will track them. A crashed laptop in a startup is annoying. A crashed laptop here is a different category of problem entirely.

We had bet the company on this moment. Six months of rebuilding every layer of the product. Front end language. Agent communication. Back end architecture. Six months of late nights, early mornings, and days that bled together. Six months of couches, conference room floors, and pizza at 2 a.m., for one customer, in one room, on one exercise we could not afford to fail.

That moment is what this book is about.

Before the titles. Before the roadmap, the metrics, or the barbell plates neatly stacked on a rack. There was the mission.

I've worn uniforms and hoodies, sat in war rooms and boardrooms. I've served with soldiers and shipped with engineers. And the one thing that always stood out — the one thing that always worked — was giving a shit. About the work. About the people. About the outcome.

That motto belongs to VMM-364 — the Purple Foxes, a Marine tiltrotor squadron whose pilots fly CASEVAC into enemy fire to bring wounded troops home. Three words on their patch. They have run my life ever since. You will meet them in their full weight in the chapter on AI.

This isn't a memoir. It's not a manual.

It's a field guide for anyone trying to build something that lasts, whether that's a body, a product, a company, or a life with integrity.

You won't find shortcuts here. Just reps. Principles. Stories from the weight room and the war room, forged in pressure, refined in reflection.

Real strength doesn't come from just lifting the weight. It comes from knowing why you're lifting it.

Now, let's get to work.

■ CHAPTER 01

01

MISSION BEFORE METRICS

THE MISSION IS THE MAGNET

Before I ever built products, I served in the U.S. Army as an Airborne intelligence sergeant. That experience of working in service of something larger than myself, of making decisions under pressure with lives on the line, shaped everything that came after. I learned early that mission comes first. Not ego. Not recognition. Mission.

That mindset followed me from the military to cybersecurity, and into leadership roles where the stakes changed but the values stayed the same. Whether it was securing critical systems, helping build Elastic Security, or coaching in the gym, the goal has always been the same: real strength is lifting others.

One of the proudest chapters of my product career was building Endgame. We entered a brutally competitive market, going head-to-head with massive players like McAfee and CrowdStrike, and carved out real ground. Not because we had more money or brand recognition, but because we had something harder to copy: a clear mission. Protect high-value targets from nation-state level attacks. That focus, and the small, fierce team who rallied behind it, made all the difference.

At the heart of it was Nate Fick, a Marine officer turned tech CEO, and later the U.S. Ambassador for Cyberspace and Digital Policy. He led with conviction, clarity, and a deep respect for the mission. In all-hands meetings, Nate would remind us that we were an "elevator asset company" — that if the building burned down, the most important assets could still fit in the elevator. It wasn't the code or the tools. It was the people: the ones who understood the user's mission and had the passion to serve it.

That idea stuck with me. Nate's example reinforced what I learned in uniform: the success is the user's success. Your mission is their mission.

Nate also brought something else with him out of uniform — a motto from the Marines. Three words from the patch of VMM-364, the *Purple Foxes*, a tiltrotor squadron whose pilots fly CASEVAC into enemy fire to bring wounded troops home. *Give a shit*. About the work. About the people. About the outcome. It became the working motto of my career, and it has been the spine of everything I have built since. We will come back to it in full in the

THE DRIFT

At first, the metric is a mirror. It reflects the mission. Clean, focused, and true.

But over time, something shifts. Quietly. Gradually. The mirror warps. And without noticing, we begin steering toward the reflection instead of the road.

This is the Drift.

It doesn't announce itself. It rarely arrives with bad intent — it begins with a goal:

- Launch the feature by Q4.
- Hit 405 on deadlift.
- Increase MAUs by 20%.

Reasonable. Measurable. Actionable. These are the numbers we hold up as evidence that we're making progress, and for a while, they are.

But then: the goal becomes the game.

In product, we've seen it time and time again. Shipping becomes more important than solving. Teams crunch to meet a date set quarters ago, long after the user problem has evolved. Metrics chase headlines. Investors want news. Executives want motion. The dashboard glows green while user trust fades red.

Think of Boeing. In the race to beat Airbus, they needed the 737 Max on runways fast. Shareholder pressure mounted. Deadlines became immovable. On paper, the metrics looked great: deliveries met, costs controlled. But beneath the numbers, safety systems were skipped, warnings dismissed.

Two crashes. Hundreds of lives lost. The drift wasn't just technical, it was cultural. Speed overtook scrutiny; the metric overtook the mission.

And here is the hard part. The Drift does not heal on its own. In January 2024, a 737 MAX 9 lost a door plug at 16,000 feet on Alaska Airlines flight 1282. No one died, but only because the seats next to the missing door were unoccupied. The plug had been reinstalled at the factory without the four bolts that were supposed to hold it in place. Same company. Same speed-vs-scrutiny pressure. Eight years after the first MCAS crash, the cultural drift was still

REPETITION WITH INTENTION

You don't get strong by lifting heavy once. You get strong by showing up again. And again. And again.

But if you do the same thing forever, you don't get stronger. You get stuck.

That's the tension of progress: it demands ritual, but it punishes repetition without variation.

Whether in the gym or in product, growth comes through iteration. Small, deliberate cycles of effort. You log your training. You tweak your form. You try a new tempo. In software, you ship. You measure. You talk to the user. You try again. The process isn't glamorous. But it's generative.

Rituals compound. Rules confine.

A rule says *"do this."* A ritual says *"do this because it matters."* One is brittle. The other bends with you.

Agile isn't magic. It's a set of rituals: standups, retros, demos, sprints. They only work when they're anchored in meaning and adapted to context. Treat retros like checkbox theater and you're looping, not iterating. If your standup sounds like *"I did stuff, I'll do stuff, no blockers,"* you've got a ritual without reason.

The same failure shows up in the gym. People find a powerlifting program online and follow it to the letter, even when it doesn't fit their recovery, their age, their job, their life. They wonder why they plateau, or get hurt. It's because they forgot the principle beneath the plan.

That's where most systems fail. Not because the framework is flawed, but because the user is forgotten. They're treated like an input to a method, instead of the reason for its existence.

Let's be honest: there's no shortage of books telling you how to do things. And yes, here we are, writing another one.

But this isn't a blueprint. It's a philosophy. The implementation is on you.

What works for one team, one lifter, one body, won't work for another. That's not failure. That's reality.

■ CHAPTER 02

02

BUILT THROUGH REPS

THE MYTH OF OVERNIGHT SUCCESS

We've all heard the stories. The product that "took off overnight." The lifter who casually pulls four plates like they've always been able to. The founder in a garage who changes the world with a single keynote.

It's tempting to believe that mastery happens like that. In a flash.

But that's not really how it works.

Take the iPhone. The 2007 reveal made it feel like it dropped from the sky fully formed. Behind that moment were years of trial and error: touchscreens that didn't quite work, software that crashed mid-demo, a mountain of prototypes that never saw the light of day. The final product wasn't a stroke of brilliance. It was relentless iteration.

Same with Instagram. What looked like an overnight success was actually the second version of a too-close-to-Foursquare check-in app called Burbn. The team just kept listening, trimming, trying again. One update at a time.

Or Cursor. The AI coding tool that seemed to dominate developer feeds in 2024 was the second product from Anysphere, a small team that had spent the previous two years pivoting from a different idea entirely. The "overnight" moment was years of quiet work on a forked IDE before anyone outside the team noticed.

That's a story I've lived from the inside. In July 2016 at Endgame, we shipped a product into a live Air Force exercise after six months of rewriting every layer of the platform. Front end language. Agent communication. Back end architecture. All of it, for one customer in one room, on one exercise we could not afford to miss. The press release made it look clean. The reality was conference room floors, 2 a.m. pizza, and a team that never went home. Polish hides process. We will come back to that exercise in the chapter on shipping. The grind that built it belongs here.

And that big deadlift on your feed? Probably not magic. More likely: a hundred quiet sessions, some of them rough. A lot of small choices to show up, tweak form, trust the program.

REPETITION IS NOT REDUNDANCY

In Section 1, we looked at the myth of overnight success — how real strength, in the gym or in product, is built through showing up again and again. But not all reps are created equal. The real magic isn't just in the repetition. It's in how you use it.

Not all reps count the same.

Anyone who's coasted through a gym session, just moving weight, knows the difference. One set burns time. Another builds awareness, precision, and strength, even if the numbers don't change.

The same is true in product.

Repetition isn't redundant when it's intentional. When it's used to test assumptions, refine interfaces, tune performance, or build something just a little closer to what users actually need. That's the kind of rep that moves things forward.

But repetition alone isn't enough. Variation is what makes repetition transformative.

In strength training, that's where Renaissance Periodization's framework lives. Dr. Mike Israetel teaches a structured progression — Minimum Effective Volume (MEV), Maximum Adaptive Volume (MAV), Maximum Recoverable Volume (MRV) — that lets lifters build under load without burning out. The concept isn't about working hard. It's about working smart, within boundaries that adapt to you.

In training, we use blocks for different goals: hypertrophy to build muscle, strength to build expression, deloads to recover and grow. We manipulate movement, load, and tempo to avoid stagnation. A paused bench press, a deficit deadlift, or chains added to a bar — each variation targets a different adaptation, even if the base movement stays the same.

Product is no different.

You might run a block of sprints to achieve a specific outcome: refining onboarding, improving performance, or tackling tech debt. Then shift into a

WHEN THE SPARK FADES

The first reps are easy. Not physically, but emotionally. You're fired up. Everything's new. Progress is loud and obvious.

But what happens after the rush?

In lifting, it's the long middle. The early PRs stop coming. Your form stalls. You show up, grind through the same sets, and wonder if you're actually moving forward. You're not always chasing your one-rep max. And you shouldn't be. Strength isn't built by living at your limit. It's built in the space between peaks, when you train with intention and recover with discipline.

In product, it's the same. You can't always be doing the flashy, innovative thing. Sometimes the most important work is foundational: fixing backend debt, improving accessibility, tightening up performance. The kind of work that creates capacity for brilliance later.

And for many, this is where the wheels come off.

Because motivation, that spark, is unreliable. It's not designed for the long haul. And it doesn't care about your goals.

That's why systems matter more than sparks.

Systems are how you keep showing up when the dopamine dies down. Morning routines. Logbooks. Standups. Progress reviews. They don't need to be rigid. But they do need to be real. Reps don't get done by accident.

You don't need hype. You need structure.

In training, that structure might be a coach, a program, a calendar alert that says *"get under the bar."* In product, it might be a rhythm of sprint planning, async demos, or check-ins with customers. Externalized accountability is often the only thing that keeps momentum moving.

James Clear, author of *Atomic Habits*, wrote:

"You do not rise to the level of your goals. You fall to the level of your systems."

THE MULTIPLIER OF BORING WORK

There's a kind of work that doesn't make headlines. No one posts their warm-up sets. No one celebrates shaving 100ms off load time.

But that's the work that wins.

For every PR pulled in competition, there are hundreds of days of grinding behind it: submaximal sets, long pauses, light reps, mental resets. The same is true in product. Every effortless-looking release rests on a foundation of something much deeper. Months of planning, iteration, bug-fixing, and late-night Slack threads.

In lifting, it's the mobility work you do alone at 6 a.m. The back-off sets you don't skip. The deload week you take seriously. It doesn't look impressive. But it makes everything else possible.

In product, it's building out role-based access controls — not because it's exciting, but because your biggest customers expect it. It's mapping audit logs across services so your platform isn't a compliance risk anymore. It's the 10th conversation with a user about the same rough edge in the UX. These aren't "big bets," but they're the reason your big bets land.

That's what boring work does: it compounds.

Each rep you don't skip, each ticket you don't shortcut, each problem you refine instead of avoid — it stacks. Quietly. Relentlessly. And over time, it becomes your edge.

You don't need to go viral. You need to be trusted.

And trust is built in the boring work.

The warm-up that prevents injury. The small fix that prevents churn. The five-second improvement that gives a user five minutes back.

This is what separates the strong from the strong enough.

It's not what you do once. It's what you do without applause.

You do it for the growth. For the discipline. For the user whose day you

THE WORK BECOMES THE WIN

At some point, the reps stop being something you have to do. They just become something you do.

You stop chasing motivation and start trusting momentum. You stop asking when it gets easy and start asking how to keep showing up.

And that's the shift. Not just in the gym or in your sprint board, but in your mindset. You lift because you care. You build because it matters. Because you love it.

It's not about PRs or product launches. It's about what they represent: the hours you logged. The patterns you learned. The people you helped.

That's what it means to be mission built.

You're not doing it for the spotlight. You're doing it because you've seen the power of the process — and you're not walking away from it.

Progress doesn't shout. It stacks.

One quiet rep at a time.

■ CHAPTER 03

03

RITUALS OVER RULES

THE RITUAL IS THE RAIL

If the mission is the magnet, the ritual is the rail.

Rituals keep us on track. Not by forcing us forward, but by guiding our momentum. Like rails under a train, they don't power the engine, but they make sure we're headed in the right direction. They keep drift from becoming derailment.

In the gym, rituals aren't written on the whiteboard, but everyone knows them. The way you chalk your hands before a heavy lift. The nod from your training partner. The slap on the back before a max attempt. These moments don't make you stronger by themselves. But they signal that it's time to lock in. They tune your mind and body to the work ahead.

In product, rituals shape how we build and why. A startup begins with a weekly sync focused on shipping a differentiated capability. As the company grows, the rituals evolve: structured roadmap reviews, tighter standups, the shift toward shipping "boring" features. Role-based access control. Data retention workflows. RBAC and audit logging won't make the cover of TechCrunch, but they're what your biggest customers need to trust you.

These shifts aren't a loss of agility. They're a deepening of commitment. The rituals grow because the mission does.

The difference between a rule and a ritual is intention. Rules are imposed. Rituals are earned. A rule says *"follow this or else."* A ritual says *"this is how we move with purpose."* When teams stop questioning why they follow a process, it calcifies into dogma. But when the process stays tied to the mission, it adapts. It grows. It stays human.

Elite lifters know this instinctively. Even as their programming changes — higher volume, lower intensity, or a shift from competition prep to recovery — their rituals stay intact. The warmup flow, the music choice, the way they approach the bar. These things evolve, but they never disappear. They guide the body into readiness. They keep the lifter connected to something deeper than the day's numbers.

And that's the point.

You don't need more rules. You need rails that carry you toward the mission.

LISTEN TO YOUR SIGNALS

Rails only work if you're paying attention to where you are on them. Rituals are no different.

You can't run the same program forever. Not in the gym. Not in product. Not in life. Progress demands feedback. And feedback starts with listening.

Lifters learn this early. You might show up ready to deadlift heavy, but your grip feels off, your back's tight, your CNS just isn't firing. (CNS, Central Nervous System, the part of your body responsible for strength output, coordination, and neural drive. If it's fatigued, you'll feel it, even if your muscles are technically rested.)

That's not failure. That's information. A smart lifter doesn't abandon the workout. They adjust. They keep the ritual, shift the intensity. Maybe you pause at 70%, maybe you pivot to accessories. Listening doesn't make you weaker. It keeps you in the game longer.

In product teams, the same truth holds: rituals without awareness become liabilities.

You can run the ceremonies — sprint planning, retros, standups — but if you're ignoring signals from your team or your users, you're performing process theater. Burnout doesn't show up in Jira. Disengagement doesn't flash red in a dashboard. You feel it in the delay before someone unmutes. In the tension after a roadmap shift. In the quiet attrition of both teammates and customers.

Nowhere is this more visible than in the game industry's long-standing reliance on crunch time. Late-stage death marches, where teams work 60, 70, 80-hour weeks to hit a ship date. Executives cite passion. Teams call it what it is: avoidable. The rituals of *"just one more sprint,"* of all-hands war rooms, of praise for pulling all-nighters — they're treated as signs of commitment, when they're actually signals of failure.

Failure to listen. To plan. To build sustainable systems. Failure to treat the team as human, not just headcount.

This is where product management has a second, often overlooked role.

CHANGE THE PATTERN, NOT THE PRACTICE

Sometimes listening reveals the ritual itself needs to change.

When things stop working, you don't abandon the ritual. You adapt it.

Progress isn't a straight line. It's a cycle of push, plateau, pivot. And when you hit that plateau — when the usual ritual no longer delivers results — it's not a sign to quit. It's a sign to evolve.

In the gym, this happens all the time. You run a successful squat cycle, adding five pounds a week like clockwork. But then you stall. Your knees cave, your speed slows, and the bar starts winning. The answer isn't to scrap the movement. It's to change the pattern. Maybe you shift to pause squats, change your stance, or drop the volume to focus on recovery. The ritual — showing up and squatting — stays. The shape of it changes.

The same holds true in product.

The standup that once helped your team sync becomes a box-checking chore. The planning meeting that used to set priorities now spirals into status updates. That doesn't mean you stop planning. It means you shift how you plan. You move from live check-ins to async threads. You replace calendar fatigue with focused, flexible rituals that match your team's needs and their current phase of growth.

Rituals that don't evolve become rules. And rules, as we've seen, break people.

This is especially true in globally distributed teams. At Elastic, our workforce spans time zones and continents. We had to learn early that rituals built for co-located teams don't translate. Sync meetings at 10 a.m. in California are 7 p.m. in Berlin, and 2:30 a.m. in Sydney. So we changed the pattern.

We moved toward asynchronous rhythms:

- Key decisions live in documents, not meetings.
- Slack threads replace sidebars.
- Recorded meetings include transcripts and tagged callouts.
- Big calls are followed by quiet time. Space for global teammates to

■ CHAPTER 04

04

**FEEDBACK IS A
SUPERPOWER**

Trust is built one cue at a time. One adjustment. One shared win.

CUES, NOT CRITIQUES

A distinction worth naming first. *Criticism* and *critique* are not the same word.

Criticism announces what's wrong. Critique tries to make the work better. Criticism is judgment. Critique is investment. Criticism comes from someone who wants to be heard. Critique comes from someone who wants you to succeed.

The same words can deliver either one. What changes is the care underneath.

This chapter is about a third thing entirely. Even the best critique can be too much in the moment. Under the bar, mid-swing, mid-presentation, you don't need analysis. You need something tighter. You need a cue.

My mentor Nate Fick used to talk about the power of laser focus. Not just attention. Precision. That phrase gets thrown around a lot, but he meant it in the truest sense.

Laser focus isn't about doing one thing. It's about doing the right thing. The move that creates the most impact. The shift that makes everything else click into place.

I saw that principle in action during my early days at Endgame.

When I joined, we had four different products, all in different markets, serving different users. Built with a small team. Sold with an even smaller one. The problem wasn't that the ideas were bad. They weren't. In fact, each had real potential.

But potential doesn't scale without focus.

Nate made a tough call. He chose to end-of-life three of the products, even though they were generating short-term revenue, and put every ounce of our talent behind a single one.

It was a risk. But it paid off.

We built a best-in-class endpoint protection product in one of the most competitive markets in cybersecurity. Not because we chased everything. But because we aligned everything to a singular mission.

That's what laser focus looks like in the real world. And feedback should work

MAKE FEEDBACK A RITUAL

Feedback isn't something you give once a quarter. It's not a Slack comment or a surprise at review time. It's a rhythm. A rep.

If cues are the spark, rituals are the circuit. They keep the current flowing. The strongest teams and the strongest lifters don't just react to feedback when it shows up. They build it in. They expect it. They practice it. They normalize it.

In lifting, you log your sets. You reflect on what moved well, what felt off, what needs attention tomorrow. Feedback isn't an event. It's a ritual. Same goes for product.

And if you're a product manager, here's the simple truth:

If you're not talking to users, you are failing at your job.

Not falling behind. Not missing a step. Failing.

User feedback isn't a bonus. It's the core ritual of the role. If you're not making regular space to listen — directly, personally — you're flying blind.

You're not a scrum master. You're not a backlog babysitter. You are the voice of the user.

The user, and their mission, is why you have a job.

The research, the roadmaps, the revenue — all of it is an outcome of solving the user's problem. Not the other way around. Too many teams fall into the trap of building for elegance, scale, or conversion, and forget to ask the most important question: *Does this move the mission forward?*

That's your job as a PM: to hold that line. Metrics can drift, roadmaps can get noisy, but the mission stays clear if you keep listening.

SLACK: FEEDBACK AS THE PRODUCT

Slack didn't start out as a product idea. It started as an internal tool. The team

LISTENING IS A LIFT

You've built the ritual. You're getting the feedback. Now comes the hard part: listening.

Not passively. Not performatively. But actually listening, in a way that helps you grow.

And here's the first thing to understand:

Being user-obsessed doesn't mean the user is always right.

Sometimes users give you feedback in the form of a solution.

"Add a new button." "Change this flow." "Make it more like what Company X does."

If you chase those suggestions blindly, you're not listening. You're outsourcing product design.

The real job of a product manager is to listen deeper. To get past the request and find the root. Don't treat the feedback as the answer. Treat it as a clue. Your job is to uncover the real problem.

One thing I'm adamant about with my PMs: we don't hand our engineers a solution. We bring them a problem worth solving.

That means doing the work. Talking to users. Studying how others have handled it. Mapping the friction. Listening for what's unsaid.

We work with brilliant, creative engineers. Our job isn't to steal the *"how."* It's to own the *"why."* And collaborate on the *"how"* together.

Because feedback isn't always clear. It's not always clean. It can be noisy, misdirected, emotional, subtle, or even wrong.

And when you're under pressure — in the middle of a hard training cycle or a high-stakes product push — it's easy to hear what you want to hear. Or to hear nothing at all.

Listening is a skill. One that separates people who just collect feedback from

STRONG FEEDBACK, STRONG FOUNDATIONS

We should strive for critique, not criticism. Feedback that's constructive, not combative.

I've learned this over the course of my career. As a passionate product leader, I've had to walk a line: how do you bring intensity without intimidation? How do you make sure your excitement doesn't land as insult?

It's not always easy. Passion can blur the edges. And in fast-moving teams, feedback can come fast and hot, even when it's meant to help.

But here's what I've come to believe:

When feedback is anchored in empathy and structured around the mission, it becomes a lift, not a weight. It pushes people forward instead of pinning them down.

These lessons apply well beyond product, and well beyond management. They show up in how we coach our teammates, how we parent, how we partner, how we grow.

If something matters enough to say out loud, then it matters enough to deliver with care.

Because what you say is only part of it. How it lands is what makes it real.

STRONG FEEDBACK IS OFTEN MICRO

We tend to think feedback has to be a big moment. A review. A reset. A speech.

But most of the feedback that actually changes people, and changes outcomes, is micro.

One cue, one adjustment, one rep at a time.

That's how coaching works on the platform. That's how great PMs guide a

■ CHAPTER 05

05

PROGRESS ISN'T PRETTY

MASTERY IS REPETITION WITH FEEDBACK

Practice doesn't make perfect. Perfect practice makes improvements.

That's the principle that separates a hundred wasted hours from a hundred that actually move you forward. The reps you log have to be deliberate. They have to be honest. They have to teach you something the next time you show up.

You see it clearly in cybersecurity.

Penetration tests are our version of reps under pressure. Simulated real-world attacks run across teams, infrastructure, and products. We don't go easy. We don't telegraph the punch. Sometimes, we don't even tell the blue team it's happening. Why? Because defenders don't get warning in the real world. If we want to build muscle memory, we need to simulate the actual weight.

That's what *perfect practice* really means. Not pristine, flawless action, but high-quality, high-context repetition.

Malcolm Gladwell's *10,000 Hour Rule*, popularized in *Outliers*, offers a compelling headline: do something for 10,000 hours and you'll become world-class. What's often forgotten, and what Gladwell himself has acknowledged, is that the number only matters if those hours are deliberate, structured, and improving. Not just any reps. The right reps.

It's a mindset that transcends domains. In lifting. In product. In leadership.

THE LIFTING LENS: PERIODIZATION AND PROGRESSION

Walk into any well-run gym and you'll see programs. 5/3/1. Texas Method. Juggernaut. Conjugate. Each offers structure, progression, and intentional overload, built on periodization: you cycle through intensities, movements, and recovery phases. It's not sexy. But it works.

Chad Wesley Smith, founder of Juggernaut Training Systems, built JTS by emphasizing smart lifting over heavy lifting. As he puts it:

"Motivation gets you started. Discipline keeps you going. Feedback tells you where to go next." — Chad

THE GRIND THAT GROWS

The reps that change you aren't the glamorous ones. They're not the PR attempts. Not the launch keynotes. Not the LinkedIn flexes. The reps that build real strength — in the gym and in the product — are the ones nobody sees. The early morning warmups. The late-night bug fixes. The process of showing up, adjusting, refining, repeating.

This is the grind. And it's where the gains are made.

IN THE GYM: WARMUPS, NOT MAX OUTS

You can spot the novices in any weight room: they go straight for the heaviest lift they can manage. They max out on deadlifts, post it on Instagram, then disappear for weeks.

The ones who stick? They warm up. They move methodically. They hit moderate numbers with perfect form. They log their progress. And they show up again tomorrow.

Warming up isn't a sign of weakness. It's the mark of a seasoned lifter. It's protection. Preparation. And part of the process. As Chad Wesley Smith and countless coaches remind us, progress is built on consistency, not bravado.

IN PRODUCT: QUIET WINS THAT MATTER

Product teams can fall into the same trap. We celebrate the big splashy features, but the real loyalty comes from the quiet wins. The "minor" UX updates that shave 10 clicks off a daily workflow. The improved loading time. The default that finally makes sense.

We saw this first-hand at Endgame. Yes, we differentiated on high-end protections like in-memory attack prevention. But the reason our champions stayed engaged wasn't just the cool stuff. It was the continuous improvement in how they used the product. With each release, we delivered smoother experiences and more intuitive workflows. It added up.

The same holds true at Elastic Security. We spent over a year deeply focused on the alert triage experience. We met with analysts. We compiled hundreds of hours of feedback. We made sure everything they needed — context,

CHANGE THE PHASE, NOT THE PROCESS

Anyone who's followed a good lifting program knows the feeling: what used to work, stops working. You stall. Plateau. Feel stuck.

The worst response? Panic and start over.

The best? Adjust the phase. Keep the process.

In powerlifting, this is where periodization becomes personal. You might deload. Shift focus to speed or hypertrophy. Swap bars or change stance. But you don't throw away your structure. You modify it with purpose.

The same is true in product development. You don't abandon the mission when progress slows. You evolve your strategy. You change the shape of the work.

PRODUCT EXAMPLE: SCALING FOR WHAT'S NEXT

Early in Endgame's life, we took an almost nine-month pause on new features to rearchitect the platform for long-term scale and performance. It was a scary bet, and there were plenty of sleepless nights wondering if it was the right call.

But when we brought the new build to a major deployment, and saw the blue team "win" their live training exercise for the first time, we knew it had paid off. Their expertise made it happen. But our new platform and agent helped enable it.

Sometimes, changing the phase means sacrificing momentum now to build leverage for later. That takes guts. But it's part of the process.

LIFTERS ADJUST, TOO

Smart lifters know when to change gears. That might mean trying a new program, like shifting from 5/3/1 to Juggernaut. Or letting an AI-based plan like JuggernautAI retune based on fatigue and bar speed. Sometimes it means getting a personal coach, or joining a lifter forum to troubleshoot sticking points.

What matters is sticking to the discipline. You're still logging reps. Still progressing with intention. The ritual stays, the phase shifts.

GROWTH THAT HOLDS

There's a difference between strength that shows up... and strength that holds up.

That difference comes from experience. From failure. From learning the hard way.

We saw it earlier in the story of Hafthor Björnsson, the world's strongest man who tore his pec pushing beyond safe limits. He later called it his "biggest mistake" and rebuilt with a smarter plan. The same pattern shows up again and again in high-level lifting. Even Stefi Cohen, one of the most decorated lifters of her generation, has shifted focus toward long-term health, adjusting how she trains, eats, and recovers, not out of fear, but out of wisdom.

These lessons apply everywhere high performance matters.

PRODUCT EXAMPLE: BUILD FAST, LEARN FASTER

At Endgame, we learned a critical lesson well before the world-shaking CrowdStrike outage of 2024. We had shipped a powerful capability: the ability to update our machine learning-based malware prevention engine out of cycle from the main product release. It meant our users got faster protection. They didn't have to wait for a full product upgrade.

It was the right feature. But it had an unintended consequence.

During Black Friday at one of our retail customers, an update disrupted point-of-sale systems. Nothing catastrophic. But enough to make an impact.

We fixed it fast. We added guardrails. We changed our rollout process. And we never made the same mistake again. More importantly, we kept the feature, and improved how it worked for the user, at their scale, in their implementation.

We learned that the best product capabilities don't just "work." They hold up.

They account for real-world usage, edge cases, and the 80/20 rule, that 80% of issues will come from 20% of scenarios. And we built resilience into the system because of it.

■ CHAPTER 06

06

**THE MISSION
DEMANDS
RECOVERY**

THE BIOLOGY OF BOUNCE BACK

Recovery isn't retreat. It's reinforcement. Whether you're lifting heavy or leading strong, progress isn't just about what you do. It's about what you recover from. And yet, in both gyms and boardrooms, recovery is often misunderstood as weakness, wasted time, or something you'll "get to later." When stress hits or deadlines loom, recovery is usually the first thing cut.

That mindset breaks things.

It's an often-repeated phrase, *"it's a marathon, not a sprint,"* but even marathons have aid stations. Recovery isn't the opposite of performance. It's what makes performance possible.

You'll notice a pattern: the strongest systems, bodies, and teams are built on rhythms, not sprints. And the ones that fall apart? They usually forgot to rest.

THE YEARS RECOVERY VANISHED

During the pandemic, the commute disappeared. And with it, the last buffer between work and rest. Working from home seemed like a win, until days began with a Slack notification and ended with Zoom still open. Lunch breaks were replaced by back-to-back meetings. Evenings bled into late-night emails. There was no off switch, just a lower screen brightness.

People didn't stop working. They stopped recovering.

It wasn't the difficulty of the tasks. It was the absence of boundaries. Parents toggled between spreadsheets and homework help without leaving their chairs. Managers tried to hold their teams together through webcams and chat threads. Even rest became another thing to optimize, a new podcast, a sleep tracker, a mindfulness app squeezed in before another call.

Burnout crept in sideways. Not as a dramatic collapse, but as a slow erosion of clarity, patience, and presence. Work got done. But purpose got blurry. People didn't crash. They faded. Not because they cared too little, but because they were never given space to come up for air.

Recovery wasn't just missing. It had been overwritten.

RAILS, NOT BARRIERS

Boundaries aren't barriers. They're rails. Not to box us in, but to keep us from going off track.

In lifting, the rails are obvious: rest days, deload weeks, technique sessions. You can grind all you want, but if you don't recover inside the structure, the system breaks. Not always with a snap. Sometimes just with a slow slide into fatigue you can't name.

In product, the rails are harder to see. And harder to hold.

This work is rarely clean. It shifts constantly between strategy and triage: vision decks one moment, sales escalations the next. Context-switching becomes the default. What you planned often gets pushed aside by what the business demands now.

Instead of pretending we can block out perfect "no meeting days," the better move is to create rails that expect the chaos but still protect time to think clearly.

Call them strategy blocks. Step-back time. Mental deloads. The name doesn't matter. The intent does: to build in space that lifts your head above the noise and lets you make intentional decisions, not reactive ones.

Because rails aren't rigidity. They're protection. For focus. For energy. For the mission.

NETFLIX AND THE SPACE TO REFLECT

Even in a high-performance culture like Netflix, boundaries around strategic thinking are built into the system. Product leaders are expected to regularly pause and reflect, not just on what they're building, but on who's building it. Their well-known "Keeper Test" asks a simple but revealing question: *Would I rehire this person for this role today?* Answering that honestly takes courage. But it also takes time. Time to zoom out. Time to get quiet enough to think clearly. In a culture that thrives on speed, those reflections are what keep the team aligned, accountable, and evolving.

Step-back time doesn't have to be silent. It just has to be sacred.

SUSTAINABLE STRENGTH

Recovery is not a reward. It's part of the plan.

In strength training, the most disciplined athletes don't just train hard. They track what fuels the work. Calories. Sleep. Macros. Because performance isn't just about what you do in the gym. It's about what you support outside of it. That's why tools like MacroFactor have become essential for serious lifters: not for vanity, but for visibility. To make sure every training block is fed with what it needs to grow.

In product, the same principle applies. You can't build a resilient team without knowing what you're feeding it. That's where tools like Jira, Aha!, or Linear come in, not just as ticket trackers, but as visibility engines. They let you zoom out. Spot overtraining. Identify where strategic work is undernourished. Recovery in product isn't just about taking breaks. It's about sustaining the energy to build well over time.

Because burnout doesn't usually come from sprinting. It comes from sprinting without a cycle.

That's why elite lifters use periodization — planning not just the next workout, but the next month, quarter, and year. They alternate intensities. Deload. Peak. Rebuild. Not because they're lazy. Because they're playing the long game.

Sustainable product teams follow the same rhythm. They don't live in permanent crunch. They push when necessary, then deliberately create time to reflect, retool, or recharge. They respect the difference between urgency and importance. And they recognize that more activity doesn't always mean more progress.

When you track your macros, you don't just know what you're eating. You know what you're aiming for.

When you track your product macros — the balance of innovation, maintenance, user research, and downtime — you build not just velocity, but viability.

One example of this kind of tracking in action comes from Atlassian's Team Health Monitors. These are not daily scrums or sprint reviews. They are recurring, focused check-ins designed to assess the long-term health of a team

RECOVERY CREATES ROOM FOR PERSPECTIVE

Halfway through the book, and at a chapter all about recovery, it's worth pausing on something that too often gets misunderstood or misused in product work: diversity as a design principle.

The acronym DEI has been politicized and weaponized. The principle behind it is older than the acronym, and more useful than the politics. Because the enemy of clarity isn't chaos. It's assumption. And when your product is only shaped by people who already know how to use it, you stop seeing what's broken.

Think about the average enterprise tool. Bloated. Confusing. Clunky. Not because the teams behind them don't care, but because they've learned to work around the flaws. They stop noticing friction because they've internalized the shortcuts. And then they add more complexity without questioning the base layer. That's not innovation. That's calcification.

Remember Apple's infamous iPhone 4 moment? When reception dropped if the device was held a certain way, the official response was: *"You're holding it wrong."* That wasn't just a PR misstep. It was a failure of empathy. A product built with a single use case in mind, and a team unwilling to question it.

This is where diverse inputs become a design discipline. Not a slogan. Not a checkbox. An actual practice. When you bring in voices that don't match your defaults — different backgrounds, different abilities, different ways of thinking — you create friction that reveals blind spots. You build products that more people can actually use.

The Medici Group teaches a powerful example of this in their innovation workshops: hospitals learning from Formula 1 pit crews. Two entirely different fields — surgery and motorsport — sharing best practices to reduce patient handoff time in operating rooms. The result? Faster triage. Fewer errors. Lives saved. That's what happens when you step outside your bubble and let diversity expand your playbook.

And sometimes, that kind of inclusion is quieter, but just as critical.

■ CHAPTER 07

07

**TRAIN THE ENGINE,
NOT JUST THE
OUTPUT**

WORK CAPACITY OVER WINDOW DRESSING

There's a difference between looking strong and being strong. You see it in the gym all the time: the lifter who chases their one-rep max every week, treating PRs like progress reports. Impressive, until the plateaus hit or the pain sets in. What you don't see as often is the lifter dragging a sled after squats. Doing walking lunges in the cold. Rowing in the morning and hitting their accessories at night. That's the engine work. That's capacity.

"If you want to go far, build the lungs before the legs."

In the training world, this is called GPP, General Physical Preparedness. It's not just a warmup or conditioning. It's the foundation for everything else.

GPP improves recovery between sets and sessions. It builds joint integrity, tissue resilience, and work tolerance. It makes your system ready, ready to train harder, recover faster, and adapt more consistently. And yet, in many strength circles, it's dismissed. You'll hear things like:

- *"Combo sets are my cardio."*
- *"I don't have time for fluff. Just the main lifts."*
- *"If it doesn't add pounds to the bar, it's a distraction."*

That's the specialization trap. And it's seductive.

Specialized programs promise fast results. Just do the thing you want to improve, more of it. Until it stops working — until your joints hurt, your energy fades, your momentum disappears, and you burn out.

Repetition without variation isn't just physically risky — it's psychologically draining. Without variation, even the most disciplined lifter starts dreading the next workout. Even the most motivated developer begins to disengage.

We've seen this in teams that only work on performance. Or only ship new features. The work becomes mechanical. Morale suffers. Curiosity fades. They're strong in one motion, but brittle under real-world load.

INTERNAL STRENGTH FOR EXTERNAL LOAD

Strength isn't just about what you can lift. It's about what you can withstand.

Anyone can show up strong once. But the mission demands more than that. It demands repeatability. Resilience. The ability to show up strong again and again, under pressure, under uncertainty, under load.

That kind of strength doesn't come from testing yourself every day. It comes from building yourself for the test, from the inside out.

We know this intuitively in lifting. If you neglect your stabilizers, your joints, your breath control, your bracing, it doesn't matter what your numbers look like. You'll break. The biggest total in the gym means nothing if your back gives out the next week. True strength isn't just output. It's the integrity of the system supporting it.

The best lifters don't chase the max. They train the margin.

That's what Amanda Lawrence understands. A multi-time world champion powerlifter, Amanda is famous not just for her records — squatting over 600 pounds raw at 84kg — but for her poise under pressure. She visualizes every meet lift weeks in advance, rehearses the rituals, manages recovery like a professional sport. She doesn't just train her muscles. She trains her nervous system, her mental process, her ability to stay composed under load.

That internal strength — not just quad size or grip — is what lets her hit massive lifts on the world stage, even when the bar bends and the cameras are rolling.

THEY TRAINED THE TENDONS OF THE PRODUCT, NOT JUST THE MUSCLE

The same applies in product.

Notion wasn't always a darling. In 2015, they were nearly dead. No traction.

WHAT POWERS YOU?

The fastest engines in the world still go nowhere without fuel.

You can have world-class systems, perfect technique, and an unbreakable schedule. But without something driving you — a reason to push through when it's hard, a mission that makes the effort matter — the engine stalls. Strength without fuel is just potential. It goes nowhere.

This is the third layer of performance. After physical preparation and mental resilience comes purpose. The why behind the work. The force that powers the engine when the load gets heavy and the results are still far away.

You can see this difference on the platform. Some lifters are chasing numbers. Others are lifting for something deeper — to test themselves, to prove something to a younger version of who they were, or to inspire someone watching from the crowd. The same weight moves differently depending on what's driving it.

The same is true in product work. Teams that ship the fastest aren't just well-organized. They're aligned around a purpose they care about. They understand the mission. They know what their work means to the people who use it. And that makes them more resilient, not just more productive.

When the fuel runs low, purpose drives on.

Take Kristy Hawkins. Before she was a record-breaking powerlifter, she was a biochemical engineer at Genentech. Whether in a lab or under a barbell, she trains with the same energy source: a relentless drive to understand, improve, and own her progress. She's powered by process, not comparison. That's what makes her strength sustainable.

The same goes for teams. Look at how Superhuman built their product. Founder Rahul Vohra didn't just want to make a faster inbox. He wanted to build the fastest, most delightful email experience ever created. They didn't launch until users said they'd be *"very disappointed"* if they lost the product. That wasn't marketing polish. It was purpose, measured. Every decision — from UI transitions to onboarding flow — was shaped by that internal fire:

■ CHAPTER 08

08

**DECISIONS ARE
MADE UNDER LOAD**

STRESS TESTS THE SYSTEM

Stress doesn't break the system. It exposes what was already weak.

We often talk about "testing under load" as a strength-building concept. In the gym, it's simple. Your ability to move weight when you're tired is the real signal of progress. But in product leadership, systems design, and incident response, stress testing is often overlooked until it's too late.

The Log4j vulnerability in December 2021 made that brutally clear. A zero-day exploit in a widely used Java library allowed remote code execution with minimal effort. Suddenly, nearly every organization had the same urgent questions:

- Are we exposed?
- Where is Log4j deployed in our environment?
- Do we have visibility into historical access or exploitation attempts?

This wasn't just a code issue. It was a test of organizational readiness — technical, operational, and strategic. Teams that had practiced incident response, mapped their architecture, and built cross-functional trust could move with purpose. Others stumbled, not because they didn't care, but because they'd never trained for the moment.

It was the backup problem, writ large. Many companies back up data religiously, but few test whether they can actually recover it. Even fewer know how long recovery will take, or what their RTO (Recovery Time Objective) or RPO (Recovery Point Objective) really are. The lesson was hard-earned: backups are only as valuable as your ability to restore fast.

Log4j forced a parallel reckoning. Malicious scanning began months before the public disclosure, but most organizations didn't retain accessible data that far back. They had cold storage — frozen or tiered off for cost savings — but had never practiced bringing it back online quickly for investigation.

When the pressure hit, teams had to figure out, often in real time, how to thaw data, unblock logs, and

CLARITY BEATS CERTAINTY

You don't need to know the outcome to know how to act.

There's a myth in leadership, and in lifting, that success comes from always having the right answer. That if you just gather enough data, wait long enough, or plan hard enough, certainty will arrive and carry you through.

But the best teams, the best lifters, the best products — they don't run on certainty. They run on clarity.

You see it clearly in moments of disruption. In early 2020, when the COVID-19 pandemic rewrote every assumption about business, teams that waited for complete information froze. But the ones who moved quickly didn't do it recklessly. They did it with intention.

- **Zoom** opened up free access to educators worldwide. Daily meeting participants skyrocketed from 10 million in December 2019 to 300 million by April 2020.
- **Peloton** overhauled its entire supply chain when demand outpaced capacity. By Q4 2020 it reported 232% year-over-year revenue growth and added over 1 million new subscribers.
- **Notion** refocused messaging for the remote work moment. Its user base grew from 1 million to over 4 million in 2020.

None of them knew how long the shift would last. But they had clarity of mission. That clarity became a compass.

This is the same clarity that high-level lifters use when training with RPE (Rate of Perceived Exertion). Instead of sticking to a fixed number on the bar, they assess how each set feels in real time. On some days, that means pulling back to preserve recovery. On others, it means pushing heavier than planned.

It's not guesswork. It's informed adaptation. It's clarity in action, even when conditions change.

TRAINING FOR CHAOS

We don't rise to the level of our plans. We fall to the level of our preparation.

In the last chapter, we explored the idea of training the engine, building general physical and mental capacity, not just specific skills. But that alone isn't enough. What happens when the plan vanishes? When you're under pressure, short on time, and forced to act without hesitation?

That's when preparation has to become instinct.

I learned this firsthand as a U.S. Army paratrooper. Before you ever board a plane, you train on the ground for weeks. You drill every movement until it's embedded. How to hook up your static line, how to check your gear, how to exit, how to land. You jump from towers. You simulate the aircraft. And you practice failure, not because you want it, but because it's coming.

You want to fail when you're four feet off the ground, not 800.

We don't take our first flight until the basics are second nature. Because stepping out the side door of a C-130 at 800 feet, in pitch black, isn't natural. It's against every self-preservation instinct. And in that moment, you don't want to be thinking through a checklist. You want to be moving.

If your main chute doesn't deploy, you have 9 to 10 seconds to respond before impact. That's it. There's no time to think. You just act.

I still remember my first jump. The roar of the engines. The rush of the open door. And when we stood up, hooked up, and waited for the green light, I didn't feel fear. I didn't feel stress.

I felt clarity.

I knew what to do. And I executed. Because we had trained for it.

That same mindset exists in the best teams, even in tech.

■ CHAPTER 09

09

**SHIP IT LIKE YOU
SHOW UP**

Empathy isn't softness. It's clarity. It's knowing what to say no to.

INTEGRITY IN SMALL THINGS

How you do the small things is how you do everything.

Greatness doesn't usually show up where we expect it. It isn't built in the spotlight. Not in PR lifts or flashy product launches. Not in press releases or headlines. Most of what truly earns trust and builds strength happens quietly. In the warmups. In the follow-through. In the care no one notices but you.

From the outside, powerlifting looks simple. Three lifts: squat, bench, deadlift. Anyone can walk into a meet and give it a shot.

But the difference between showing up and winning isn't about size or intensity. It's about discipline. The small things. The lifters who win are the ones who move with precision.

The bar comes out of the rack the same way every time. The breath is controlled. The bar path is tight and deliberate. The brace is locked in. The foot pressure is balanced. And they do it the same way whether it's 135 pounds or a max-effort lift.

That's where mastery comes from: consistency under load.

Watch Olympic lifter Lu Xiaojun and you'll see it. People celebrate his explosive strength, but what makes him exceptional is his control. Every rep is intentional. Every rerack is clean. There's no ego in his movement, only precision. He lifts like someone who knows that how you finish matters just as much as how you start.

This is what the best product teams understand too.

Anyone can ship a feature. But not everyone takes the time to check whether the error message makes sense. Not everyone notices if the cursor lands in the right input field. Not everyone asks if the experience feels smooth or rushed.

But when someone does, users feel it. Even if they don't know why. It's the difference between something that works and something that feels right.

At GitHub, engineers fix what they call papercuts: small friction points most

THE SHIPPING STANDARD

A clean lift on the platform tells you more than any gym session ever could.

You can move big numbers in training, hit personal records, and feel confident under your own rhythm. But step onto the platform at a meet, and everything changes. The commands are faster. The lights are brighter. The room is louder. The pressure is real. And even with the same weight on the bar, your form starts to slip.

Not because you lack strength, but because you didn't train for that moment.

Building is like training. Shipping is competing.

And competing demands more than power. It requires control, presence, and precision when the world is watching. It also introduces more variables than training ever does. In the gym, you control the pace, the setup, and the rhythm. But on the platform, you might face a cold bar, unfamiliar flooring, a tight timeline, or commands that arrive quicker than expected.

Shipping is no different.

In development, teams test the happy path. In production, users rarely follow it. They skip steps, input bad data, use features in unexpected ways, and still expect everything to work. These edge cases aren't theoretical — they are reality. That's the difference between building in private and shipping in public. That's what it means to compete.

At Netflix, shipping isn't something saved for the end. It's part of every step. Engineers own their code from the first line to long after it's live. They test it, monitor it, tune it, and fix it when needed. There's no handoff. No deflection. Accountability is shared.

Staging environments mirror production closely, simulating real user behavior and traffic patterns. Netflix teams know you can't expect consistent performance unless you train in the conditions you'll actually face. They don't celebrate heroics after a failure. They celebrate readiness before one. That's how they maintain quality under pressure.

Shipping is a team sport, and the teams that win align around a shared

EVERYTHING BUILT IN

At the highest level, strength isn't brute force. It's total integration. Each breath, angle, and cue refined until nothing is wasted.

Lu Xiaojun isn't dominant because he trains harder. He's dominant because his training is complete. His grip, his breath, his core, and his positioning are aligned. There is no wasted motion. Every part of his movement supports the next. He's not just strong. He's unified.

Product teams face a similar challenge. It's easy to chase what's next, the shiny feature, the headline for the release notes. But when something new is added without regard for the whole, it often unsettles more than it improves. Instead of adding value, it reveals what's missing. Instead of delighting users, it creates friction in places that once felt natural.

That's why product managers need to pause. Not just to evaluate whether something can be built, but whether it belongs. Does it complete the user's experience? Does it connect meaningfully to the rest of the platform?

The goal isn't just to deliver functionality. It's to ensure everything in the system makes more sense because it's there.

Lu doesn't just train the bench press. He trains the setup, the position of his feet, his breathing under load, and his recovery. Strength alone doesn't make a champion. What matters is the integration of every part.

Product should be no different.

A new feature can introduce more problems than it solves if it isn't thought through holistically. It can expose what's missing more than it reveals what's new. PMs need to take a step back and evaluate not just the capability, but the completeness of the capability across the entire product suite. That completeness is what creates trust.

One of the clearest illustrations of this lives far from software. It lives in a hospital.

At Great Ormond Street Hospital in London, a pediatric cardiac surgery team noticed something troubling. Their operations were world-class, but the transition from surgery to intensive care, the most critical moment, was prone

■ CHAPTER 10

10

THE TEAM IS THE TOOL

SPOTTERS SAVE MORE THAN REPS

Spotters are often seen as the quiet figures standing near the bench or squat rack, but their role is anything but passive. A good spotter wears many hats: a safety net ready to intervene if failure would cause harm, a form checker watching for breakdowns in technique, a source of subtle cues like *"tighten up"* or *"drive through."* Yet the essence of a spotter's job is restraint. They give just enough help, if any, to let you challenge yourself safely and build real strength.

"A spotter's purpose is to help you lift, not to lift for you."

This same principle shows up in the best peer reviews. When a teammate reviews your code, design, or plan, they are not there to rewrite your work. Their goal is to provide insights you might have missed, highlight potential risks, and offer alternative perspectives. Done well, a review leaves the author better prepared to own and improve their work, not dependent on the reviewer to fix it. The best peer reviewers, like the best spotters, are vigilant but hands-off until needed.

Similarly, in product work, the feedback we gather from users should act like a spotter's cues. Engaged users tell us what is confusing, what is delightful, and what is missing, helping us see where to focus. But they do not dictate the solution. They guide our decisions with their lived experience. If we lean too hard on user feedback as a script, we lose our strategic intent. Like a lifter expecting the spotter to lift every rep, we stop growing.

Even in the boardroom, we do not go in cold. Before a major strategy session or executive presentation, we run documents by trusted colleagues and dry-run meetings to anticipate hard questions. These are forms of spotting. The spotter's goal is the safety and growth of the lifter, not their own performance — and the same is true of the colleagues who review your work.

Skipping spotters by rushing in without preparation is like dropping the weight in front of your peers. You overlook a key stakeholder's concern.

TRUST IS A SHARED PR

In powerlifting, a personal record, or PR, is celebrated not just by the lifter but by everyone who helped them reach it. Spotters, coaches, training partners. Each person who encouraged, corrected form, or simply showed up to support shares in the success. Trust grows strongest in these moments because the lifter knows they could not have done it alone, and the team feels ownership in the accomplishment.

"A shared PR is a shared story, one that bonds people together and makes them eager to keep showing up for each other."

In product work, trust is forged the same way. When teams win together — landing a major customer, resolving a critical outage, or shipping a complex feature — the shared achievement becomes a foundation for deeper collaboration. Trust grows not because of individual heroics, but because people see each other invest, struggle, and succeed side by side.

Shared PRs in the workplace are not just milestones. They are reminders that we are stronger as a team than as individuals.

A personal example comes from working alongside my former engineering peer, Tony Meehan. We had a strict rule when communicating to the team: never use I statements. Our reasoning was simple. There was nothing we accomplished in that job that was done alone, so saying *"I did this"* or *"I fixed that"* was incorrect. Everything became *"we"* or *"the team,"* even in small wins. We also made it a habit to take blame when things went wrong and defer credit when things went right. This simple discipline created a culture of shared ownership, where trust was built through consistent signals that no one succeeded or failed alone.

This mindset helped us build a world-class endpoint at Endgame by sharing the mission, the credit, and the responsibility with everyone involved. We avoided the false pretense that leaders single-handedly make everything happen. The truth is, we are only as strong as our team. Our real job as leaders is to clear the path for our team's success, remove obstacles, and ensure

THE TOOL YOU INVEST IN

Every lifter knows that your tools matter. Barbells with tight tolerances, smooth bearings, and well-maintained knurling do not just make lifting more enjoyable. They make it safer, more effective, and more consistent. Investing in quality equipment is not about appearances but about performance and longevity. Neglecting your tools leads to unpredictable outcomes, unnecessary risk, and wasted effort.

The same is true in building products and teams. The most important tool you will ever invest in is your people. Yet in too many organizations, especially those led by egocentric founders or executives, the energy and focus go toward building a cult of personality instead of investing in the team that actually delivers results. These leaders chase personal brand moments — keynotes, interviews, social media spotlights — while their people struggle with lack of resources, shifting priorities, and unclear goals. Companies like these are not designed to lift everyone up. They are designed to keep one person at the top.

WeWork under Adam Neumann is a prime example. Neumann's obsession with his personal image and extravagant lifestyle overshadowed the needs of the company and its employees. His behavior bred chaos and instability, culminating in WeWork's spectacular collapse, which hurt thousands of workers and investors who had trusted in the vision of one person rather than a strong team.

I preach the complete opposite. Our role as leaders is not to cultivate an image of ourselves as saviors or visionaries. It is to clear the path so our teams can do their best work, remove obstacles, and set them up for success without making ourselves the story. A leader who needs to be the hero will always sacrifice team health for personal glory. A leader who makes the team the hero builds lasting strength.

Consider Microsoft under Satya Nadella. By shifting

■ CHAPTER 11

11

STRONG ENOUGH TO LISTEN

The hardest lift you will ever make is putting your ego down.

LISTENING AS LEADERSHIP

In lifting, the strongest athletes don't just follow cues. They seek them out. They crave feedback on form, timing, and control, knowing every correction is a chance to grow. But this hunger for insight doesn't end at the gym doors. The same mindset defines exceptional leaders: they don't listen to reply. They listen to understand.

Listening as leadership begins with presence. It's easy to nod while you plan your response, but transformative listening happens when you quiet your thoughts long enough to hear what the other person truly needs. Whether it's a training partner describing discomfort under the bar or a teammate raising a concern in a product sprint, the act of listening says: *I value you, and I value what you see.*

We've all interacted with someone who claims to want feedback but argues or shuts down when it's given. Or worse, nods along while rehearsing their rebuttal. In lifting, these athletes plateau or get hurt. In leadership, the consequences are subtler but just as damaging: a culture where honesty fades, mistakes repeat, and innovation stalls.

When people feel their leadership is unwilling to listen or routinely ignores feedback, they stop engaging. Leadership becomes something to avoid rather than trust. Interactions with managers feel like a tax on progress instead of a path to improvement, and silos begin to form as people retreat to spaces where they feel heard or simply left alone.

Feedback exists for a reason. It's an outside perspective that reveals what we can't see ourselves. Day after day, trapped in our own heads, we start to self-reinforce ideas, sometimes bad ones. Without external input, flaws harden into habits.

But feedback must also be given responsibly. Some people weaponize "feedback" as an excuse to be cruel or condescending. Great leaders know that effective feedback is clear, focused on actions, not personal attacks, and delivered with the intent to build, not break. It's the difference between saying, "You suck at this," and "You could improve by keeping your elbows tighter during the press." One demoralizes. The other empowers.

LISTENING BETWEEN THE LINES

Good leaders listen to words. Great leaders listen beyond them. Because what people say rarely tells the whole story. The subtext — the hesitation in a voice, the glance across a table, the silence after a loaded question — often reveals more about what's really happening than the words alone.

In lifting, an athlete might claim they're fine while shifting uncomfortably under the bar. You can hear it in their breath, see it in the wavering setup, or sense it in the way they rack the bar with relief instead of resolve. A coach who misses these cues risks pushing an athlete to injury or letting a lack of confidence fester unaddressed.

In the workplace, the same dynamics unfold. A teammate may say *"I'm good with this plan"* while their tone flattens or their posture closes off. They might contribute less in meetings, or their messages become shorter and less engaged. These are signals leaders must learn to read, because they're early warnings of misalignment, burnout, or growing resentment.

Listening between the lines isn't about mind-reading. It's about active listening. Active listening is the set of techniques that helps you tune into more than words:

- **Observe nonverbal cues.** Pay attention to body language, facial expressions, eye contact, posture, and gestures. Discomfort, stress, or disagreement often shows up physically before it's spoken.
- **Reflect and paraphrase.** Repeat back what you heard in your own words. It shows you're tracking, and it gives the other person a chance to clarify or expand. For example, *"So you're saying the timeline feels tight, but you think it's still doable?"*
- **Ask open-ended questions.** Questions like *"How do you feel about this approach?"* or *"What would you change?"* invite honest responses and help surface unspoken concerns.
- **Pause intentionally.** Silence can feel uncomfortable, but giving space after someone speaks often encourages them to share more, especially when they sense you're patient enough to truly listen.

THE EGO LIFT

Some leaders believe the biggest threat to success comes from the outside: competitors, market shifts, or resource constraints. But often, the greatest danger to a team or organization is internal. An unchecked ego at the top. Ego convinces leaders they alone have the answers, blinds them to new information, and makes them resistant to change. It transforms what should be shared missions into personal crusades, suffocating the creativity and collaboration needed to adapt and excel.

The ego lift shows up when leaders believe their title grants them absolute knowledge or when athletes refuse coaching because they think they know best. These moments look like confidence, but they're actually insecurity disguised as bravado. And they poison teams faster than almost anything else.

Listening doesn't work when ego stands in the way. A leader might nod along waiting for their turn to speak, or worse, interrupt to redirect the conversation back to themselves. The effect is the same: people stop sharing. Meetings become performative. Feedback withers. Silos grow. The organization slows down.

This is the dark mirror of what we explored at the end of the last chapter: leaders who claim they alone have the vision and who force alignment through dictation instead of inspiration. They believe respect comes from authority, not credibility. These explicit-authority leaders declare a path without inviting discussion, mistaking fear for alignment. Under their command, teams comply outwardly while disengaging inwardly, working to avoid conflict rather than achieve greatness.

It's the leadership equivalent of *"because I said so."* Seniority doesn't always mean smarter. Experience brings valuable insight and intuition, but it is not infallible. Fresh perspectives can break stale patterns. The famous example of Formula 1 pit crews inspiring hospital surgical teams to improve patient handovers — healthcare teams saved lives because the mission mattered more than their egos.

Leadership is also a constantly evolving role that demands continuous learning and adaptation. In *What Got You Here Won't Get You There*, Marshall Goldsmith describes how the very traits that once fueled a leader's success can

■ CHAPTER 12

12

**THE WEIGHT IS
REAL. OWN IT.**

DON'T DODGE THE HEAVY SETS

The heaviest sets in the gym teach you what you're made of. Your technique frays, your breathing shortens, and every fiber of doubt tries to talk you out of the next rep. But if you dodge those sets, if you forever add weight "*next time*" or cut the range of motion when it gets tough, you never find the limits you're capable of surpassing.

Like a calendar laid out with intention, the night before a big lift becomes a ritual of mental preparation. Scanning tomorrow's workout, knowing there's a 1RM attempt or a set taken to true zero Reps in Reserve, sparks both nerves and excitement. These are the days you celebrate the grind, the day-to-day discipline that built your capacity. The moment the bar bends under load is your chance to prove how far you've come. When you finally log that PR in your fitness app, it's not just a number. It's evidence of your commitment, and the right to earn a well-deserved deload.

Product work has its heavy sets, too. The planning sessions, the heated debates over priorities, the painstaking designs, all culminate in one make-or-break moment: the release. When the new feature goes live and real users experience your work, it's the equivalent of stepping onto the platform. The high isn't just about shipping. It's the culmination of every rep of preparation, and the point where your investment meets reality.

One of my favorite parts of being in product management is visiting my users. My career has been spent building cybersecurity software, but before that, I was a defender who relied on those very tools to protect my teams. That experience infused me with deep empathy for the difficulty of the job, the importance of effective tools, and a healthy resentment for the snake oil promises that plague our industry.

Every time I step on site at a customer's Security Operations Center, I get a mini-experience of my old life. For those few hours, I live in their shoes, seeing the threats they face, the urgency they feel, the challenges that keep them awake at night. I love being in the fight with them, brainstorming new ways to integrate with the rest of their stack, and, most of all, witnessing the moment when what we built helps them win. Because when their mission

THE RESPONSIBILITY TO FINISH

In strength training, a lift isn't counted until it's locked out. Until control is clear, the bar is steady, and the rep is complete. A squat that's buried deep but racked before standing tall, or a deadlift that's ripped off the floor but dropped before lockout, doesn't earn a place on the scoreboard. The intent doesn't matter if the execution isn't finished. The responsibility to finish is about more than effort. It's about seeing your mission through until the work is undeniable.

The same truth echoes through product management. A brilliant idea or well-laid plan means nothing if it stalls at 90%. Too often, teams sprint through exciting early stages — brainstorming, whiteboarding, the rush of discovery — but lose steam when the grind sets in. The last mile demands relentless focus on details that don't win applause: validating integrations, testing obscure edge cases, polishing onboarding flows, aligning final documentation, preparing enablement, and ensuring stakeholders are ready. These tasks can feel tedious, but they are the difference between a product that earns trust and one that frustrates users.

One of the most powerful commitments I made to myself came when Endgame joined Elastic. I promised I would never stop advocating for our Endgame users. That I would ensure their mission remained as critical and deeply embedded within Elastic as it was before we joined. To Elastic's credit, they readily accepted this challenge. Together, we strengthened our platform until our Endgame customers were not only supported, but measurably better protected than ever before. That was the responsibility to finish in action. Not letting the work pause at the point of acquisition or integration, but carrying it forward until the promise made to users was fully honored.

When a user buys a product you helped create, they're placing their trust not just in the brand, but in you. Not every product carries the same stakes. Misprinted playing cards might frustrate a game night but won't bankrupt a family. But in cybersecurity, you're building your customers' shield. They rely on your expertise and vigilance to help defend their business, their livelihoods, and the security of the people who depend on them. When you build security

THE LIFT AND THE LEGACY

From the outside, both powerlifting and product seem attainable by anyone — and in reality, they are. Anyone can step into either and make an attempt.

However, both require focus and nuance to excel. Minute details like the path of the bar or a user's non-verbal cues separate the truly elite from everyone else. In lifting, a subtle shift in balance or a half-second of hesitation can mean the difference between a successful PR and a missed attempt. In product, a poorly timed question or a missed signal in a customer conversation can derail alignment or cause you to build something that solves the wrong problem.

The barbell is a teacher of both moments and memories. A heavy lift can change your understanding of what you're capable of in a single instant, but the deeper value comes from what that lift means over time. The discipline to prepare, the courage to attempt, and the commitment to finish leave a legacy. Not just in your personal record books, but in the culture you build around you. Those who watch you lift learn not just about strength, but about character.

In product work, the same legacy unfolds. Our choices ripple beyond immediate wins or losses. The way we engage with teams, the care we put into the final details, the honesty of our conversations with customers — these moments compound into reputations that either build trust or erode it. When you choose to embrace a user's mission as your own, you send a message: that their success matters, that they are not alone, and that their mission deserves the best you can give.

I've found some of my proudest moments in product come not from flashy announcements or big conference stages, but from quiet emails and calls months after release. Customers sharing how what we built helped them solve a problem, achieve a goal, or simply feel heard and supported. Those stories remind me that while our work can feel abstract behind code and roadmaps, it becomes real and meaningful in the hands of the people whose lives it touches. Their victories are our legacy.

But legacy can also turn negative if we forget the responsibility we carry. A lift done sloppily in front of new lifters teaches them that form and safety don't matter. A rushed feature full of bugs teaches a team that deadlines

■ CHAPTER 13

13

**AI IS THE NEW OS.
THE MISSION IS THE
ONLY APP THAT
MATTERS.**

The chapter you've been reading toward.

Across the previous twelve chapters, AI has shown up at the edges of almost every principle in this book. In Chapter 2, it could do the boring reps for you, but the reps that grow you still belong to whoever shows up willing to feel them. In Chapter 6, it became a teammate that doesn't sleep, doesn't deload, and doesn't take Q4 off, which means the recovery problem is now also a problem of deciding when to walk away from the available output. In Chapter 8, it changed what stress-tests look like — from the months-long Log4j shape to attackers moving in seconds. In Chapter 10, it joined the team. In Chapter 11, it surfaced a question we were not yet ready to answer: it can hear what gets said, but can it hear what gets meant? In Chapter 12, it became the most dangerous line in any review meeting: *"the AI did it."*

This is where those threads converge. Not as a defense of AI, and not as an attack on it. As an honest test of whether the book's principles still hold when the work itself is changing under our feet.

The motto that runs this chapter is the same one that runs the rest of the book. *Give a shit.* I planted it in the prologue, where I named its source — VMM-364, the Purple Foxes, the Marine tiltrotor squadron whose pilots fly CASEVAC into enemy fire to bring wounded troops home. I traced it through Nate Fick at Endgame in Chapter 1. I lived a version of it in my own Army intel work in Chapter 8. Now I have to test it against the loudest tool of the year I finished writing this book.

So we will. Twice. Once under the bar. Once in the boardroom.

\$13.1 · AI IS THE NEW OS. THE MISSION IS THE ONLY APP THAT MATTERS.

AI UNDER THE BAR

I program with JuggernautAI. It watches my sets, learns from them, and reprograms when it needs to. Fatigue shows up, the plan adjusts. Tweak a hamstring, it backs me off. Hit a PR, it pushes harder next cycle. It is the closest thing to a real coach in your pocket that has ever existed.

But it does not lift the bar for me.

That is the part most people miss when they first hear about AI in training. They hear "*AI program*" and assume the work just got easier. The work did not get easier. The work got smarter, and the responsibility shifted.

The whole system runs on one input: the truth. How many reps did I really have left? Did I actually hit depth, or did I cheat the angle because the camera was off? Did I sleep, or did I tell the app I slept? AI cannot guess. It can only respond to what I tell it. If I lie to the app, the program lies back to me. If I show up honest, the program finds me ground I would not have found alone.

That is the trade. AI gives you a coach. You give AI the truth.

Here is what I have come to believe: AI does not replace the work. It exposes the people who were never doing the work in the first place.

For years, getting a real strength program meant one of two things. Either you could afford a coach you trusted, who knew your body and would adjust your block when your knee was angry, or you got lucky finding the right template online and disciplined enough to follow it without modification. Most lifters never had either. They followed something they read in a forum in 2014. They never deloaded. They never adjusted volume around life. They trained for years and barely moved their numbers.

They were doing the reps. They were not really training.

That is the failure AI just removed. Not the failure of effort. The failure of access.

A good AI program is not magically better than a great human coach. A great coach who knows you, watches you move, and pushes you at the right

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THE ONLY APP THAT MATTERS.

AI IN THE BOARDROOM

I run product with Claude as a teammate. It reads my epics and asks me what I missed. It builds wireframes from a written brief in minutes. It summarizes a competitor's last six press releases before my coffee is cold. It drafts sections of a roadmap I would have spent an evening on. It is the closest thing to a senior editor and a junior designer and a research analyst in your pocket that has ever existed.

But it does not feel what the user feels.

That is the seam in this whole conversation. The discourse around AI in product management has been quick to declare the role obsolete. Engineers can prompt their way to an epic. AI can summarize a customer call. Anyone with the right tools can ship a working prototype before lunch. The argument goes: if all of that is true, what does the PM still do?

Let's be honest about the answer. *Robotic* is already the word we use when a person responds without empathy. *"That answer was robotic."* *"Don't be so robotic with the customer."* It is not a compliment when we apply it to a human. So why would it be the goal when we apply it to how products get built?

We do not want robots building experiences. We need empathy. We need relation. We need a human.

That motto — *give a shit* — is the line. A model can render empathy convincingly. It cannot live it. It can mimic the language of caring. It cannot actually care. The Purple Foxes flew into enemy fire because someone on the other end was bleeding. That is not a workflow. That is not a prompt. That is what humans do for other humans when nothing else will do. It is also what product work, at its best, is. And it is the part of the work AI is not crossing.

The whole system runs on one input: presence. Did you actually sit with the user, or did you let AI summarize the call? Did you watch them try the workflow, or did you ask the model what frustrated them? Did you carry their problem home with you, or did you tag the recording and move on?

■ CONCLUSION

14

GIVING A SHIT
WORKS

At every stage of my life — whether wearing a uniform, defending networks, under a barbell, or building a product — I kept running into the same lesson: giving a shit works.

We've already talked about those nights advocating for air assets while serving as an intelligence analyst overseas. When the real challenge wasn't the data, but the conversations, the negotiations, and the weight of knowing that if I couldn't make the case clearly, people downrange might not get the support they needed. Giving a shit wasn't optional. It was the difference between letting things happen and fighting for what mattered most.

I saw the same pattern later as a SOC analyst and lead defending some of the largest government networks in the world. The best defenders weren't always the smartest or the fastest. They were the ones who gave a shit enough to search for the serendipitous connections between seemingly disparate events — the deep analyses that led to the discovery of attacks in time to stop damage and loss to critical systems. The analysts with empathy for teammates, respect for users, and pride in their work were the ones who set the tone.

When I moved into product management, giving a shit meant obsessing over the details of problems I'd lived myself. How slow alert triage wasted defenders' time, or how confusing interfaces kept critical data hidden. At Endgame, in a mature, crowded EDR market, our willingness to listen to defenders, to give a shit about their realities, helped us build a product recognized as a Visionary by Gartner. When Endgame was acquired by Elastic, giving a shit meant betting on the users again. Launching Elastic SIEM, building the Elastic Security division from the ground up, and in just a few years, earning recognition from Gartner and Forrester as one of the leaders in a fiercely competitive SIEM space. But more important than any analyst recognition was the validation from our users. Real stories of success, attacks mitigated, remediation accelerated, and defenders delighted. That was the true measure of whether we gave a shit enough.

Under the barbell, giving a shit took a different shape. It meant tracking tiny progress when nothing felt like it was changing, resting on days when ego screamed to push harder, and spotting a training partner with the same care you'd want from them. It meant seeing that strength isn't just what you can lift, but how you show up for others. Because real strength lifts others.

And then came the year I finished writing this book, and the year I had to add

COLOPHON

Set in Oswald, Merriweather,
and JetBrains Mono.

Designed and built in 2026.

Read the live edition at missionbuilt.io.

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MISSION BUILT · END

**REAL STRENGTH IS
LIFTING OTHERS.**

